

Cyber Threat Intelligence Report

07th of November 2026

TLP:CLEAR - May be shared publicly

Binance $6.34 Billion Theft: Fake Interview, Poisoned Coding Task, Stolen Developer Tokens

Risk Level

☐ CRITICAL

☑ HIGH

☐ MEDIUM

☐ LOW

Report ID

TW-CTI-2026-002

Incident Overview

Incident: Theft of about $6.34 billion in digital assets from Binance on 29 October 2026

Threat Actor: North Korea (FBI attribution); the tactic matches the Contagious Interview campaign

Initial Access Vector: Social engineering of engineers: a fake job interview with a malicious coding task

Timeline: Tampered download in June, fake interview in September, theft on 29 October

Impact

Who is affected: Organizations that hire engineers or give developers access to production or wallet systems, especially cryptocurrency, fintech and software companies.

Attackers moved from one engineer's laptop to internal developer tooling and stole deployment tokens, which let them hijack the wallet signing service. Binance reported about $6.34 billion stolen and about $2.85 billion frozen, and thefts continued for nearly four hours after the first. Rated HIGH for firms whose engineers can reach money-moving systems: one developer endpoint was enough.

ATTACKER OBJECTIVES AND KILL CHAIN

Objectives

- **Steal digital assets:** take control of Binance's wallet signing service.
- **Gain a foothold:** use social engineering to compromise an engineer, then move to internal developer and AI tooling.
- **Keep withdrawing:** reporting says the attackers abused Ethereum's EIP-7702 delegation to continue after Binance began isolating its network.

Kill Chain

- **Preparation:** In June 2026 a wallet engineer downloaded a tampered Homebrew installer delivered through an advertisement. Binance replaced the device, but internal details about engineering roles were taken.

- **Delivery:** In September the attackers approached another engineer on a legitimate job-search platform, posing as a recruiter for a fictitious company. After interviews they sent a coding assignment hosted on a public repository.

- **Execution:** Running the assignment executed malicious code on the engineer's macOS laptop. It replaced the pyenv tool in the Homebrew directory with a trojanized copy (pyenv_) that launched a hidden zsh shell.

- **Persistence and control:** The tool opened an encrypted reverse shell to an attacker-controlled server. Over several weeks the attackers used an internal AI development tool to compromise two more wallet engineers and take their container deployment tokens.

- **Actions on objectives:** On 29 October they used the stolen tokens to run a malicious script against the wallet signing service and drained about $6.34 billion.

TECHNICAL DETAILS

Binance's published investigation describes two separate intrusions. In June 2026 a wallet infrastructure engineer installed a tampered Homebrew download delivered through an advertisement. Binance replaced the device after noticing anomalies, but the attackers had already obtained internal details about engineering roles. In September, using that knowledge, they approached a different engineer through a legitimate job-search platform with an interview for a fictitious company. The approach matches the Contagious Interview (Operation Dream Job) tactic that researchers have tracked and linked to North Korea.

After building trust through interviews under a false identity, the attacker sent a coding assignment hosted on a public repository. Running it compromised the engineer's macOS work computer. According to the reporting, the code deleted the pyenv executable in the Homebrew directory, planted a malicious replacement named pyenv_, changed symbolic links and launched a hidden zsh process that opened an encrypted reverse shell to an external server.

From that foothold the attackers moved over several weeks, using an internal AI development tool to reach two more wallet engineers and collect their container deployment tokens. On 29 October they used those credentials to run a malicious script against the internal wallet signing service. Binance reported about $2.85 billion frozen, and thefts continued for nearly four hours after the first. Reporting also says the attackers abused Ethereum's EIP-7702 delegation mechanism to keep funds moving after Binance began isolating its network.

INDICATORS AND DETECTION

Host artifacts (macOS developer machines)

- The pyenv executable in the Homebrew directory deleted and replaced by a binary named pyenv_
- Changed symbolic links for pyenv
- An unexpected zsh process started by pyenv
- An encrypted outbound connection from a developer laptop to an unfamiliar external server

Behavioral indicators

- Unsolicited recruiter contact on a job platform, followed by a coding assignment from a public repository
- Container deployment tokens used from unusual places, or to run unusual scripts against wallet infrastructure

Recommendations and References

Recommendations

- **Today:** Run interview tasks and any untrusted code only in disposable virtual machines or sandboxes that are separate from the corporate network and credentials.
- **Today:** Warn engineers and recruiters about this tactic. Treat coding tests from unknown recruiters with suspicion, and never run them on a work laptop.
- **This week:** Use EDR to watch developer tool directories (for example Homebrew) for replaced binaries or changed symbolic links, and alert on unexpected shells started by developer tools.
- **This week:** Limit what internal AI and developer tools can reach, and monitor their sessions, so one compromised laptop cannot harvest other engineers' tokens.
- **This month:** Require independent multi-party approval for deployments that touch wallet signing or other money-moving systems, and shorten the life of deployment tokens.
- **Crypto firms:** Review how withdrawal-suspension controls handle EIP-7702 delegations.

References

- https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/binance-says-fake-job-interview-led-to-63-billion-crypto-heist/
- https://www.helpnetsecurity.com/2026/11/04/binance-hack-north-korea-fake-job-interview/
- https://axios.com/2026/11/03/north-korea-job-interview-binance-heist

STAY VIGILANT

Implement these recommendations to protect your organization from this threat.

For Support

Email: info@threatwire-intelligence.com

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